if he might perform the pilgrimage to Mecca first. When the sultan allowed it, Bairam got on a boat and sailed to Sindh instead.

Such quick thinking gave Bairam Khan a reputation for military and political genius that has survived centuries, but even he couldn't rescue Humayun's campaign against Shah Husain. Three months after Bairam arrived, in the summer of 1543, Humayun gathered his few remaining men and abandoned his ambitions in Sindh – and thereby any hope of a covert return to Hindustan via Sher Shah's western borders. Instead, he decided to venture into Kamran's realm. He would go to Qandahar.

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As Humayun prepared to pick at the scabs of his fraternal feud, a new rivalry was developing in his harem. The idyll of that first nursing ceremony, Akbar suckling at the breasts of his many mamas – the affectionate term for mothers and mother figures in Turki – was too perfect to last. Now, Akbar was seven months old and his mamas were at daggers drawn. As Jiji Anaka fed the baby one evening, a woman called Maham Anaka, superintendent of Akbar's nurses, led a delegation of discontented foster mothers to Humayun, declaring, that Jiji was 'practising incantations so that . . . the prince . . . should not accept anyone's milk but her own'.

Humayun's response is unrecorded, nor is it the point of this story, told many years later by Jiji Anaka to Abul Fazl. The point is this: as Jiji sat disconsolate, the child in her arms began to speak. 'Be of good cheer,' he said, 'for the celestial light of the *khilafat* shall abide in thy bosom and shall bestow on the night of thy sorrow the effulgence of joy. But see that thou reveal this our secret to no one, and that thou dost not proclaim untimely this mystery of God's power, for hidden designs and great previsions are infolded therein.'

Jiji was surprised, naturally, by such portentous eloquence from the infant at her breast, but it had its effect: 'sorrow's knot was at once loosed from off my heart'. What was a little domestic friction, after all, in the face of divine revelation?

In obedience to the baby's command, and suspecting, wisely enough, that any mention of it would only attract unkind remarks about the 'weakness of [her] intellect' from unsympathetic rivals, Jiji told no one of the miracle. When, a few weeks later, the company set off for Qandahar, she alone knew